

C724

Information Systems Management

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

What this is. Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

Source. Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	_____	

Items

1.

A hospital system, running on a server cluster installed in 2021, stores every patient's check-in and discharge time. A weekly dashboard turns these into average wait time by department, which managers use to plan staffing. What is the dashboard?

- A. Hardware output of the 2021 cluster
- B. Information
- C. Knowledge
- D. Data

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

2.

A discount airline, founded in 2004 and flying 60 routes, invests in self-service kiosks and mobile boarding passes that cut its cost per passenger. Which competitive strategy does this system mainly support?

- A. Focus
- B. Cost leadership
- C. Differentiation
- D. None; efficiency systems never create advantage.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

3.

A regional sales director who manages 14 reps uses a tool that lets her change price, discount and volume assumptions and see projected profit under each scenario before setting next quarter's prices. What type of system is this?

- A. Transaction processing system
- B. Management information system
- C. Executive support system
- D. Decision support system

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

4.

A firm buys a server for \$40,000. Each year it pays \$6,000 for maintenance, \$2,000 for power and cooling, and \$10,000 in admin labor. The vendor's sales rep has a long relationship with the CIO. What is the four-year total cost of ownership?

- A. \$58,000
- B. \$72,000
- C. \$112,000
- D. \$40,000

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	____	

5. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A system's five-year TCO is \$150,000, and its purchase price was \$50,000. Assuming equal yearly costs, what is the annual operating cost?

- A. \$100,000
- B. \$30,000
- C. \$40,000
- D. \$20,000

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	____	

6.

A retailer's top strategic goal this year is to improve customer retention. The CIO proposes a large data lake project because it is cutting-edge, and a competitor just announced a similar project. How should leadership decide?

- A. Approve it; the newest technology always creates advantage.
- B. Let IT decide alone, since the project is technical.
- C. Fund it only if it is shown to support retention better than other options, with business leaders involved.
- D. Approve it to match the competitor.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	____	

7.

A startup with six developers who code in Python wants to deploy its own custom web app without managing servers, operating systems or patching. Which cloud service model fits best?

- A. Platform as a Service (PaaS)
- B. Software as a Service (SaaS)
- C. On-premises servers
- D. Infrastructure as a Service (IaaS)

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

8. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A company moves its email to a SaaS provider. Which responsibility stays with the company?

- A. Patching the email application.
- B. Nothing; the provider is responsible for everything.
- C. Maintaining the physical servers.
- D. Managing its user accounts, access rights and data.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

9.

Ransomware, which entered through an email that appeared to come from a supply vendor, encrypted a clinic's files. Staff could not open patient records for two days. Investigators confirmed no data was copied out or changed. Which element of the CIA triad was mainly compromised?

- A. Availability
- B. Confidentiality
- C. All three, as in every attack
- D. Integrity

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

10. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which control mainly protects the integrity of data?

- A. Encrypting stored files.
- B. A firewall, which protects all three equally.
- C. Hashing and digital signatures that reveal any change.
- D. Redundant servers and backup power.

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

11.

A CRM system, selected after demos from four vendors, costs \$200,000 and is expected to deliver \$260,000 in benefits over its life. What is the ROI?

- A.** 30%
- B.** 23%
- C.** \$60,000
- D.** 130%

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

12. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

An IT project cost \$80,000 and earned an ROI of 25%. What were its total benefits?

- A.** \$320,000
- B.** \$100,000
- C.** \$80,000
- D.** \$20,000

Target word	The one fact that decides	Answer	[] sure [] unsure [] guess
_____	_____	___	

STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

1. Answer B Concept 1

A hospital system, ~~running on a server cluster installed in 2021~~, stores every patient's check-in and discharge time. A weekly dashboard turns these into average wait time by department, which managers use to plan staffing. What is the dashboard?

Target word: classify the dashboard **Decides:** Raw times processed into a meaningful summary.

A	Camouflage	The platform does not decide the classification.
B	Correct	Data organized into a useful context for decisions.
C	Adjacent category	Knowledge is the managers' understanding applied to act, not the report.
D	Confusion set	The raw time stamps are data; the dashboard is processed.

2. Answer B Concept 2

A discount airline, ~~founded in 2004 and flying 60 routes~~, invests in self-service kiosks and mobile boarding passes that cut its cost per passenger. Which competitive strategy does this system mainly support?

Target word: strategy supported **Decides:** The system lowers cost per passenger for a discount carrier.

A	Confusion set	Focus targets a narrow niche; nothing in the stem narrows the market.
B	Correct	Lowering unit cost supports a low-price strategy.
C	Adjacent category	Differentiation makes the offering unique for a price premium; the goal here is cost.
D	Absolute language	Efficiency supports cost leadership when it fits the strategy.

3. Answer D Concept 3

A regional sales director ~~who manages 14 reps~~ uses a tool that lets her change price, discount and volume assumptions and see projected profit under each scenario before setting next quarter's prices. What type of system is this?

Target word: system type **Decides:** Interactive what-if modeling for a semi-structured decision.

A	Inverted operation	TPS records transactions; it does not model scenarios.
B	Adjacent category	MIS gives routine summary reports, not interactive modeling.
C	Confusion set	ESS gives top executives broad dashboards, not detailed pricing models.
D	Correct	DSS supports semi-structured decisions with what-if analysis.

4. Answer C Concept 4

A firm buys a server for \$40,000. Each year it pays \$6,000 for maintenance, \$2,000 for power and cooling, and \$10,000 in admin labor. ~~The vendor's sales rep has a long relationship with the CIO.~~ What is the four-year total cost of ownership?

Target word: four-year TCO **Decides:** $40,000 + 4 \times (6,000 + 2,000 + 10,000)$.

A	Wrong stem number	Counts one year of operating costs instead of four.
B	Adjacent category	Operating costs only, leaving out acquisition.
C	Correct	Annual costs $18,000 \times 4 = 72,000$; plus $40,000 = 112,000$.
D	Dropped element	Purchase price only.

5. Answer D Concept 4 • transfer

A system's five-year TCO is \$150,000, and its purchase price was \$50,000. Assuming equal yearly costs, what is the annual operating cost?

Target word: solve for annual operating cost **Decides:** $(150,000 - 50,000) / 5$.

A	Adjacent category	Five-year operating total, not annual.
B	Dropped element	150,000 / 5 leaves the purchase price in.
C	Inverted operation	Adds the purchase price instead of subtracting it.
D	Correct	$\$100,000 / 5 = \$20,000$.

6. Answer C Concept 5

A retailer's top strategic goal this year is to improve customer retention. The CIO proposes a large data lake project because it is cutting-edge, ~~and a competitor just announced a similar project~~. How should leadership decide?

Target word: basis for approving IT investment **Decides:** IT is a managed resource tied to business strategy.

A	Absolute language	New technology helps only when it serves the strategy.
B	Adjacent category	Governance requires business ownership of IT priorities.
C	Correct	Alignment ranks IT projects by their support of strategy.
D	Camouflage	A rival's move does not show fit with this firm's goal.

7. Answer A Concept 6

A startup ~~with six developers who code in Python~~ wants to deploy its own custom web app without managing servers, operating systems or patching. Which cloud service model fits best?

Target word: cloud model **Decides:** They write the app but do not want to manage the OS.

A	Correct	PaaS runs your code while the provider manages the platform.
B	Confusion set	SaaS provides the vendor's app, not a place to run yours.
C	Inverted operation	Maximizes the management work they want to avoid.
D	Adjacent category	With IaaS you still manage the OS and patching.

8. Answer D Concept 6 • transfer

A company moves its email to a SaaS provider. Which responsibility stays with the company?

Target word: customer duty under SaaS **Decides:** The provider runs the app; the customer owns its data and users.

A	Inverted operation	The SaaS provider patches the app.
B	Absolute language	Shared responsibility always leaves data and access to the customer.
C	Adjacent category	The provider owns the infrastructure.
D	Correct	Identity and data remain the customer's job in every model.

9. Answer A Concept 7

Ransomware, which entered through an email that appeared to come from a supply vendor, encrypted a clinic's files. Staff could not open patient records for two days. Investigators confirmed no data was copied out or changed. Which element of the CIA triad was mainly compromised?

Target word: which CIA element **Decides:** Records were unreachable; not exposed or altered.

A	Correct	Authorized users could not access the records.
B	Confusion set	No data was disclosed.
C	Absolute language	Attacks differ; the stem rules out disclosure and change.
D	Adjacent category	No data was changed.

10. Answer C Concept 7 · transfer

Which control mainly protects the integrity of data?

Target word: control matched to integrity **Decides:** Integrity means detecting or preventing unauthorized change.

A	Confusion set	Encryption mainly protects confidentiality.
B	Absolute language	No single control covers all three equally.
C	Correct	They detect unauthorized modification.
D	Adjacent category	These protect availability.

11. Answer A Concept 8

A CRM system, selected after demos from four vendors, costs \$200,000 and is expected to deliver \$260,000 in benefits over its life. What is the ROI?

Target word: ROI **Decides:** $(260,000 - 200,000) / 200,000$.

A	Correct	$60,000 / 200,000 = 30\%$.
B	Wrong stem number	$60,000 / 260,000$ divides by benefits instead of cost.
C	Adjacent category	Net benefit, not a return rate.
D	Dropped element	$260,000 / 200,000$ skips subtracting the cost.

12. Answer B Concept 8 · transfer

An IT project cost \$80,000 and earned an ROI of 25%. What were its total benefits?

Target word: solve for benefits **Decides:** $\text{Benefits} = \text{cost} \times (1 + \text{ROI})$.

A	Inverted operation	$80,000 / 0.25$ divides instead of multiplies.
B	Correct	$80,000 \times 1.25 = 100,000$.
C	Wrong stem number	The cost itself.
D	Adjacent category	The net gain, not total benefits.

Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

	Right	Wrong
Sure	Owned.	Concept inversion — top priority. A wrong mental model; it survives rewording.
Unsure / guess	Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer.	Not learned yet.

Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

Trap	What it does	In this drill	Your misses
Dropped element	Leaves out a required term or step.	3	
Wrong stem number	A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.	3	
Adjacent category	The right idea in the wrong bucket.	12	
Inverted operation	Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower.	5	
Absolute language	Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.	5	
Confusion set	Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.	6	
Camouflage	Answers a stem fact that was never the question.	2	

Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

#	Concept	Rule	Trap	Tell
1	Data, information, knowledge	Data are raw facts; information is data processed into a useful context; knowledge is understanding applied to act on information.	Calling any system output “data”, or any summary “knowledge”.	Raw readings vs. a summarized report vs. expert judgment.
2	IT and generic competitive strategy	IT creates advantage by supporting the firm’s chosen strategy: cost leadership, differentiation, or focus.	Assuming any efficiency gain means differentiation, or that new tech alone is a strategy.	A system that lowers unit cost vs. one that makes the offering unique.
3	Types of information systems	TPS records daily transactions; MIS produces routine summary reports; DSS supports semi-structured what-if decisions; ESS gives executives high-level views.	Calling any reporting tool a DSS.	Routine report vs. interactive what-if modeling.
4	Total cost of ownership	TCO = acquisition cost + all operating, support and labor costs over the full useful life.	Counting only the purchase price or only one year.	A purchase price plus several annual costs and a multi-year life.
5	Business-IT alignment	IT is an organizational resource; projects are chosen and ranked by how well they support business strategy, with business leaders involved.	Picking technology because it is new or because a rival has it.	A tech project proposed without a link to the stated business goal.
6	Cloud service models	IaaS: you manage OS and up. PaaS: you manage only your code and data. SaaS: you use the vendor’s app and manage your data and users.	Thinking the provider is responsible for everything in SaaS.	Who patches the OS, who writes the app, who controls user access.
7	The CIA triad	Confidentiality = no unauthorized disclosure; integrity = no unauthorized change; availability = access when needed.	Treating every incident as a confidentiality breach.	Whether data was exposed, altered, or made unreachable.
8	ROI for IT investments	ROI = (benefits – cost) / cost.	Dividing benefits by cost without subtracting, or dividing by benefits.	A project cost and a total benefit figure.

Course scope (public description): Information Systems Management provides an overview of many facets of information systems applicable to business. The course explores the importance of viewing information technology (IT) as an organizational resource that must be managed, so that it supports or enables organizational strategy.